



Photographs by SANJAY SONKAR

LUCKNOW

Political Parties

A fatwa forbidding Muslims to break bread with politicians has been given the royal ignore. The diktat was issued by the Lucknow-based Nadwat-ul-Uloom Dar-ul-Ulema just before Ramzan. "The real reason behind throwing such gatherings is political. The organiser has his vested interests in mind while hosting the party. On many occasions, the host does not even know Islamic traditions," Mufti Zahoor Nadwi of the Dar-ul-Ifta (the department in charge of fatwas) had stated in the edict. But Ulema Council of India chief Maulana Khalid Rashid Firangi Mahali differs. "Such iftar parties were organised as a sign of communal harmony and as a goodwill gesture," he says. Several Urdu dailies have decided to boycott news about political iftar parties. But Hisam Siddiqui, editor of the Urdu weekly *Jadid Markaz*, says, "Those who issue such fatwas don't know the social fabric of India. They think they are living in Saudi Arabia, and want to isolate Muslims. Such parties offer an interactive platform and help others understand the positive side of Islam." To cash in on Ramzan and the Muslim votebank, both the SP and the BSP have started hosting lavish iftar gatherings, with Mulayam Singh Yadav leading the party pack. Fatwa or no fatwa, politicians certainly know how to keep the minorities appeased during the holy month.

MULAYAM SINGH'S IFTAR PARTY IGNORED A FATWA AROUND SIMILAR GATHERINGS

by Farzand Ahmed

8

is the number of Lok Sabha constituencies in Uttar Pradesh where Muslims make up more than 30 per cent of the electorate.